

General Knowledge

Static GK

STUDY NOTES

United Nations



United Nations

The United Nations (UN) is an international organization **established in 1945** by 51 countries following World War II. Its primary objectives are to maintain international peace and security, foster friendly relations among nations, and promote social progress, better living standards, and human rights.

History

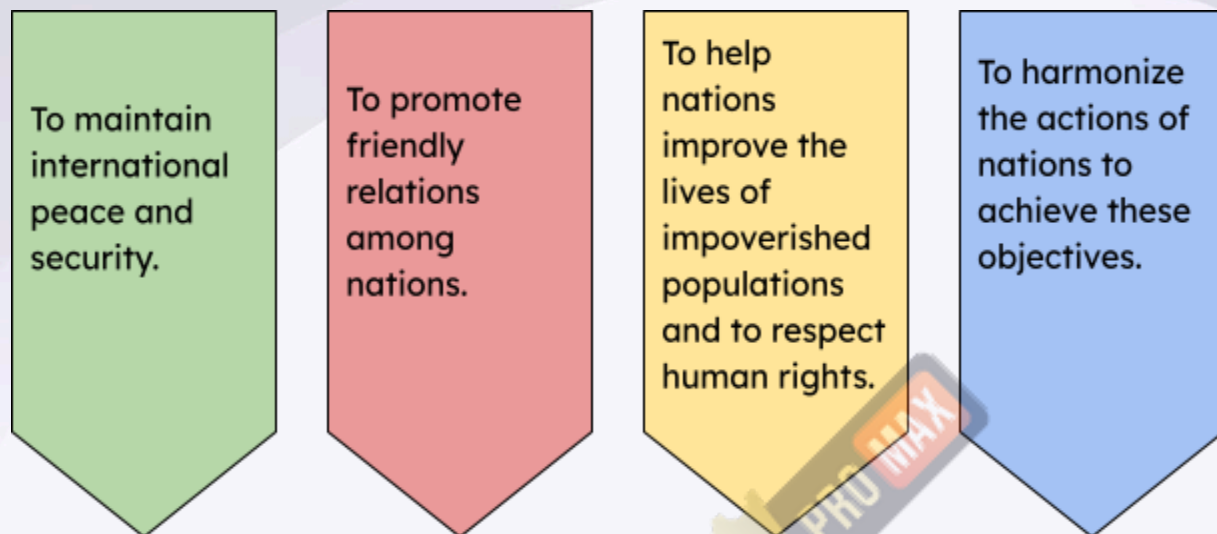
- **Dumbarton Oaks Conference (1944):**
 - Key discussions among leaders from the UK, China, the US, and the Soviet Union to formulate a blueprint for an international organization.
- **San Francisco Conference (1945):**
 - Representatives from 50 countries finalized the UN Charter, signed on June 26, 1945. Poland, although not represented, is recognized as the 51st original member.

Important Facts about the United Nations

- The UN was established on October 24, 1945, following the end of World War II.
- Headquarters: The UN headquarters is located in New York City, USA.
- As of now, there are 193 member states in the UN.
- The UN has six official languages: Arabic, Chinese, English, French, Russian, and Spanish.

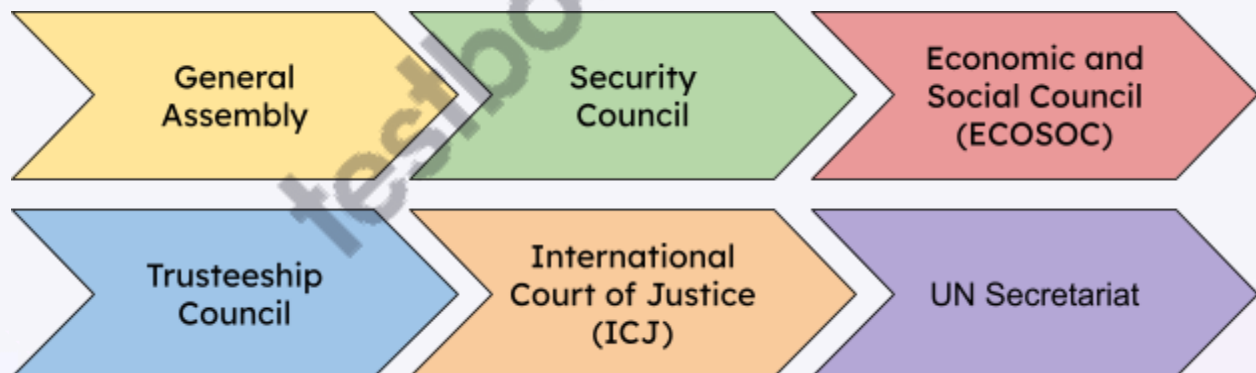
Purposes of the United Nations

The UN serves four main purposes:



Structure and Organization

The UN consists of **six principal organs**, each with distinct functions and responsibilities:



1. General Assembly

- **Composition:** All 193 Member States are represented, each having one vote.
- **Functions:** The General Assembly is the main deliberative body of the UN. It addresses issues such as peace and security, budgetary matters, and the admission of new members.

- **Sessions:** Regular sessions are held annually from September to December, with special sessions as needed.
- **Decision-Making:** Important decisions require a two-thirds majority; other decisions are made by a simple majority.

2. Security Council

- **Composition:** Comprises 15 members—five permanent members (China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom, and the United States) and ten non-permanent members elected for two-year terms.
- **Responsibilities:** Primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security. It can authorize peacekeeping missions, impose sanctions, and approve military action.
- **Voting System:** Each member has one vote. Procedural decisions require nine votes, while substantive decisions require nine votes, including the concurring votes of all five permanent members (the "veto" power).

3. Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

- **Composition:** 54 Member States are elected for three-year terms.
- **Functions:** Coordinates economic, social, and related work among the UN and its specialized agencies. It also discusses international economic and social issues and makes policy recommendations.
- **Activities:** Hold annual sessions and various thematic meetings focusing on topics like sustainable development, human rights, and social issues.

4. International Court of Justice (ICJ)

- **Location:** Based in The Hague, Netherlands.
- **Functions:** The principal judicial organ of the UN, the ICJ resolves legal disputes between states and gives advisory opinions on international legal issues.
- **Jurisdiction:** Its jurisdiction extends to cases brought by states and advisory proceedings requested by UN organs and specialized agencies.

5. Trusteeship Council

- **Purpose:** Established to oversee the administration of Trust Territories and ensure their progression toward self-governance and independence.
- **Status:** Its work was completed by 1994 when the last Trust Territory (Palau) attained independence. The Council has since suspended its operations but can reconvene if needed.

6. Secretariat

- **Role:** The Secretariat carries out the day-to-day work of the UN and services other principal organs. It administers the programs and policies established by these bodies.
- **Leadership:** Headed by the Secretary-General, currently António Guterres, appointed by the General Assembly upon the Security Council's recommendation.
- **Functions:** Activities include peacekeeping operations, mediation of international disputes, research and analysis on social issues, and organizing international conferences. Staff members work as international civil servants, maintaining neutrality and independence.

Member States of the United Nations

- Currently, the UN comprises **193 Member States**.
- Membership is open to peace-loving states that accept the obligations of the UN Charter.

Admission Process:

- A state submits an application to the Secretary-General and declares acceptance of the Charter.
- The Security Council reviews the application; a recommendation requires nine affirmative votes, with no veto from permanent members.
- If recommended, the application goes to the General Assembly, where a two-thirds majority is needed for admission.

Work of the United Nations

The UN's work addresses numerous global challenges, including:

- **Peacekeeping and Humanitarian Assistance:** Providing support in conflict zones and during natural disasters.
- **Sustainable Development:** Promoting initiatives to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).
- **Human Rights:** Advocating for the protection and promotion of human rights globally.
- **International Law:** Upholding international legal standards and resolving disputes through judicial mechanisms.
- **Disaster Relief:** Coordinating international efforts to respond to natural disasters and humanitarian crises.

INDIA AND UNITED NATIONS

Overview

- The United Nations (UN) operates in India through a system of **26 organizations**, led by the Resident Coordinator, who represents the UN Secretary-General.
- This team collaborates with the **Government of India to address key development goals and promote sustainable development** aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Strategic Support to India

- The UN provides strategic support to help India tackle poverty, and inequality, and promote sustainable development.
- The UN's involvement in India is guided by the **United Nations Sustainable Development Framework (UNSDF)**, which outlines a partnership framework between the Government of India and the UN to achieve national priorities and the SDGs.

UNSDF Focus Areas

The UNSDF focuses on seven key areas:

- Poverty and Urbanization
- Health, Water, and Sanitation
- Education and Employability
- Nutrition and Food Security
- Climate Change, Clean Energy, and Disaster Resilience
- Skilling, Entrepreneurship, and Job Creation
- Gender Equality and Youth Development

Core Principles

- The UNSDF emphasizes leaving no one behind, ensuring **equity and inclusion** in development efforts, and addressing the needs of marginalized communities.

Key Milestones in UN-India Relations

- **Signing of the UN Charter (1945):** India was one of the original signatories.
- **Establishment of ILO (1946):** The International Labour Organization became the first independent specialized agency of the UN in India.
- **Adoption of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948):** India played a significant role in its drafting.
- **Nehru's Address to the UN (1948):** Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru emphasized India's commitment to the UN Charter.
- **First Woman President of UNGA (1953):** Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit made history in this role.
- **India's Peacekeeping Commitment (1953):** First deployment of Indian troops under UN command in Korea.
- **International Day of Non-Violence (2007):** Declared on Mahatma Gandhi's birthday.
- **Polio-Free Declaration (2014):** India was declared polio-free after significant vaccination efforts.
- **First All-Women Peacekeeping Contingent (2007-2016):** Deployed to Liberia to enhance peace and security.

The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) in India

- India is pivotal in achieving the SDGs globally.
- The government has entrusted NITI Aayog with coordinating efforts related to the SDGs, while the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) develops national indicators for tracking progress.

